CULTURALLY RELEVANT PEDAGOGY

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Introduction

This study is an exploration of the use of Culturally Relevant Pedagogy in youth work. ***Culturally Relevant Pedagogy (CRP)*** is defined by Ladson-Billings (1995) as a pedagogy that is specifically committed to a collective empowerment for young people. It integrates the cultures of school, home, and community into the teaching and learning environment of young people (Brown-Jeffy and Cooper, 2011).

Culturally Relevant Pedagogy includes three foci:

- Students must experience academic success
- Students must develop and/or maintain cultural competence
- Students must develop a critical consciousness through which they challenge current status quo of social order

In addition to formal schooling environments, CRP is used in many informal education and youth work settings. This study was conducted to better understand how and why urban youth workers chose to use CRP in their work.

Significance of Study

Culturally Relevant Pedagogy (Zenkov, 1995; Seidl, 2007; hooks, 2010) and a related theoretical model called Social Justice Youth Development (Ginwright & James, 2002; Ginwright & Cammarota, 2002; Akom, Cammaorta & Ginwright, 2008) have been shown to be quite successful in urban youth work and to increase the achievement of the youth within these settings. The significance of this study is trifold:

1. To address a gap in the literature. Previous studies have revealed positive outcomes of young people engaged in Culturally Relevant Pedagogies yet there is limited evidence to support these practices. This study will provide additional evidence to support these practices.
2. To provide evidence for policy makers, funders and administrators of urban youth work. Policy makers and funders need more education and evidence to support their funding and implementation of Culturally Relevant Pedagogy.
3. Finally, this study will provide evidence of these practices as they exist in the community. It will allow community-based knowledge to impact higher education and support the need for Youth Studies and youth work training programs that prepare youth workers for engagement with urban and marginalized youth.

Research Questions

1. What motivates you to use culturally relevant pedagogy?
2. How do you perform culturally relevant pedagogy in your work?



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Methods

DATA COLLECTION

This study used an ethnographic and case study orientation (Madison, 1995) to obtain accurate results. A qualitative research approach was used that focused on gaining an in-depth understanding of the behavior, the experience and the values of the subjects. Interviews were conducted and transcribed by the primary author.

PARTICIPANTS

Active community engagement as a youth worker was the only requirement when selecting participants.

PARTICIPANT CHARACTERISTICS

- There were four participants
- There were two males and two females.
- All were African American or bi-racial.
- All of the participants were from urban areas.
- All of the participants had at least 2 years experience in youth work.

DATA ANALYSIS

A systematic analysis of the data was used to create themes. Additionally, a member check system was used to create different groups while coding for purposes. This system allowed the author to compare and contrast the themes.

Preliminary Results

- Experience and background knowledge play an important role in youth workers performance

  "I seen other people doing things like Freedom school… I was a part of Freedom school as a kid… So I got involved… now I am my site coordinator"

- Youth workers acknowledged the need for more young voices to be heard in the urban communities

  "These young people come from all walks of life and different parts of the city but all of them have something to say and they have the will power and drive to take action when needed"

- Youth workers reported culturally focused programming helped youth develop ownership in their lives

  "Seeing how our scholars developed and perceived the [Freedom School] message was so powerful for me…it was life changing"

Discussion

Youth workers in urban communities appeared to utilize ***Culturally Relevant Pedagogy*** in their youth work practice. Youth workers used community-based theory and personal experience which revealed a deep integration of the factors suggested as important by Brown-Jeffy and Cooper (2011) including "cultures of school, home, and community into the teaching and learning environment" (p. 67). They furthermore saw themselves as "part of" rather than "separate from" the communities they served. These results reveal that youth workers support the collective empowerment of young people and the maintenance of cultural competence and consciousness that are essential to CRP (Ladson-Billings, 1995).

This study has shown that ***Culturally Relevant Pedagogy*** is being practiced in youth programs in urban communities. Further exploration of CRP in Youth Work could provide evidence to policy makers and administrators to develop youth programs. Additionally, it could support the development of youth and urban studies training to prepare youth workers for working in urban settings. Current literature that supports Culturally Relevant Pedagogy is based on the practicees performed in the formal educational setting. These findings have shown that there is a distinct difference in the way CRP is performed in the formal educational settings and the informal youth work settings. Continued research on CRP in the informal settings is advised.

Select References

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